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Pheretima posthuma). Earthworms are also conveniently classified based on their ecological strategies as **epigeics, anecics** and **endogeics** (Figure 4.1). Epigeics (Greek for "up on the earth") are surface dwellers, eg. *Perionyx excavatus* and *Eudrilus eugeniae.* Anecics (Greek for "out of the earth") are found in upper layers of the soil, eg. *Lampito mauritii, Lumbricus terrestris.* Endogeics (Greek for "within the earth") are found in deeper layers of the soil eg. *Octochaetona thurstoni.*

Classification

Phylum	:	Annelida
Class	:	Oligochaeta
Order	:	Haplotaxida
Genus	:	*Lampito*
Species	:	*mauritii*

Morphology

Lampito mauritii is commonly found in Tamil Nadu. It has a long and cylindrical narrow body which is bilaterally symmetrical. *L. mauritii* is 80 to 210 mm in length with a diameter of 3.5 – 5 mm, and is light brown in colour, with purplish tinge at the anterior end. This colour of the earthworm is mainly due to the presence of porphyrin pigment. The body of the earthworm is encircled by a large number of grooves which divides it into a number of compartments called **segments** or **metameres** (Figure 4.2). *L. mauritii* consists of about 165 – 190 segments. The dorsal surface of the body is marked by a dark mid dorsal line (dorsal blood vessel) along the longitudinal axis of the body. The ventral surface is distinguished by the presence of genital openings. The mouth is found in the centre of the first segment

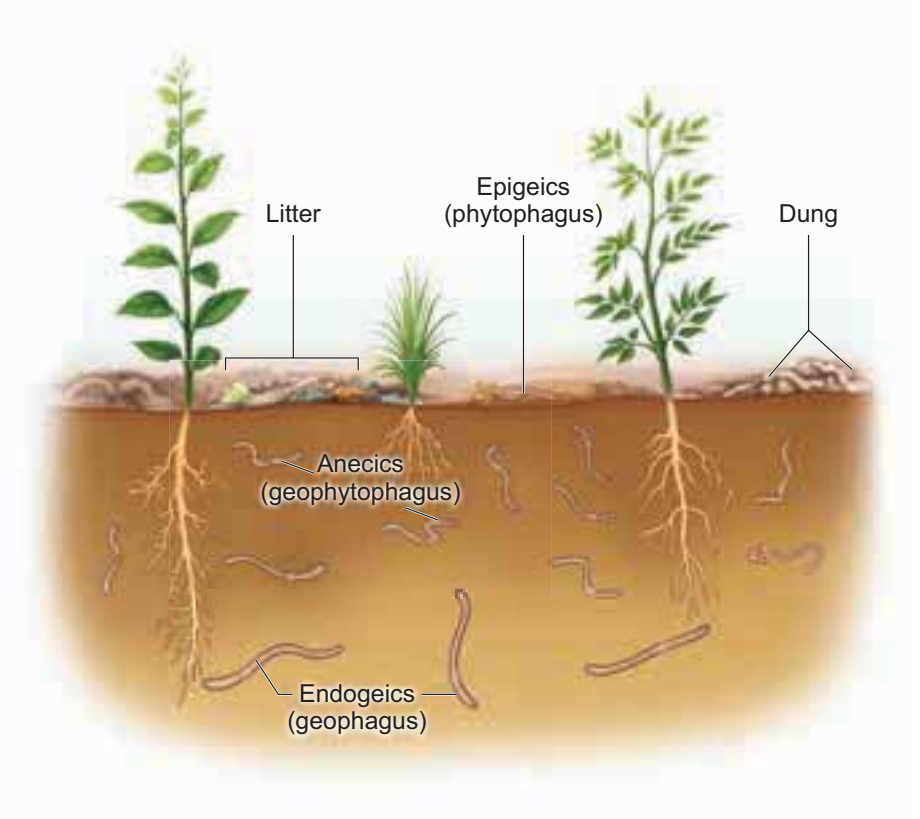


Figure 4.1 Earthworm classification based on ecological strategies